

"A little bit of a life raft" – Exploring the Use and Experiences of ChatGPT as a Support Tool among Adults with ADHD

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Abstract

Adults with ADHD face diverse challenges in executive functioning, social communication, and emotional regulation that traditional support systems and technologies often fail to address comprehensively. With the increasing mainstream accessibility of generative AI tools like ChatGPT, members of the ADHD community have begun experimenting with these general-purpose technologies to support their self-identified needs. To understand how adults with ADHD are appropriating and experiencing ChatGPT as a support tool in their everyday lives, we conducted a seven-day diary study and interviews with 13 adults with ADHD who use the tool regularly. Our findings highlight how it is used to bridge communication gaps between neurotypical and neurodivergent perspectives and to support executive function and emotional regulation. By examining a tool adopted by, rather than designed specifically for, individuals with ADHD, this study provides experiential insights that inform future inclusive design strategies and supportive technologies.

CCS Concepts

• Human-centered computing → Empirical studies in HCI.

Keywords

Attention-Deficit/Hyperactivity Disorder (ADHD), ChatGPT, support tool, diary methodology, social communication, executive function

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1 INTRODUCTION

In recent years, Human-Computer Interaction (HCI) and technology research have begun to focus on technology support for neurodivergent groups, including people with Attention Deficit Hyperactivity Disorder (ADHD) (e.g., [36, 45, 132, 133]). Historically viewed as a childhood condition, ADHD is now recognised as a lifelong neurodevelopmental profile that continues into adulthood. It is characterised by a pattern of cognitive, behavioural, and emotional traits, including differences in executive functioning, attention patterns, and emotional regulation [14, 18, 21, 79, 126, 129]. It is associated with impacts on many aspects of daily living, from social relationships to productivity and overall well-being [3, 4, 20]. The neurodiversity paradigm [47, 127] and the social model of disability [95, 133] have emerged as important lenses to understand these impacts, highlighting how many challenges arise not from inherent deficits, but from environmental misalignment with neurodivergent ways of thinking and working. These perspectives stand in contrast to the way technology support for ADHD has typically been approached in HCI research. As Spiel et al. [133] highlight, existing technological interventions often fall short by framing ADHD primarily through a medical or deficit lens, prioritising behavioural correction and neurotypical conformity over empowerment, while offering limited opportunities for meaningful participation of people with ADHD in the design and development of these tools. In this paper, we aim to respond to this critique by foregrounding the experiences and motivations of adults with ADHD as they appropriate an emerging

and rapidly evolving consumer technology, generative AI, for their own support needs.

One such technology is OpenAI's ChatGPT¹ - a large language model chatbot designed to engage in conversational interactions and capable of understanding and generating human-like text responses. Released to the public in November 2022, ChatGPT marked a turning point in the mainstream accessibility of generative AI, prompting widespread experimentation across various communities, including those with ADHD. We had observed members of the ADHD community across social media platforms (e.g., Reddit²³), blogs (e.g., ADDitude⁴), and online news sites (e.g., Mashable⁵, Independent⁶) documenting their use of ChatGPT to support what were perceived as challenges of their ADHD. We also drew on a survey study by Campbell et al. [36], which identified that knowledge workers with ADHD were experimenting with artificial intelligence (AI) tools and strategies to manage their everyday work in the office. As alluded to in Campbell et al.'s study, ChatGPT's general-purpose generative capabilities offer the capability to respond to different ADHD experiences, traits, or challenges in potentially rich and unique ways. Unlike specialised assistive technologies, which may be costly or stigmatising, ChatGPT, among other language model technologies, offers a widely accessible platform that can be personalised to individual needs without requiring specific therapeutic or technical expertise. This low barrier to entry makes generative AI particularly well-suited for spontaneous, user-driven adaptation, allowing individuals to shape the technology around their own needs and contexts.

Understanding how individuals with ADHD use and appropriate everyday technologies is important for several reasons. Related work has shown that whilst people with mental health conditions use technology in similar ways to the general population for communication, social connection, and accessing health-related information [40], they face unique barriers, such as stigma, cost, and usability challenges, and may adapt these tools in distinctive ways to manage their symptoms and daily functioning [109, 121]. A recent paper by McNally and colleagues [99] that is complementary to our work documents how autistic TikTok creators share strategies to use ChatGPT to navigate neurotypical environments, complete tasks, and manage well-being across a variety of situations. A key perspective in this line of research is Hartblay's notion of "disability expertise" [74]: the contextual knowledge and agencies that the disabled develop and perform in negotiating relationships with the designed world. Additionally, understanding user-driven technology use and appropriation can also point to opportunities for future development [22, 26, 40, 50, 109]. Examining the use of everyday technology by neurodivergent individuals, rather than focusing on specialised assistive tools, may provide insights into lived experiences, desires, access barriers, and natural coping strategies, and

reveal opportunities for scalable designs, training, or scaffolding more tailored to their needs [29, 60, 63, 133].

In this paper, we present a qualitative study examining how adults with ADHD use ChatGPT in their everyday lives. Grounded in logged episodes of use, which we subsequently explored in participant interviews, our study highlights key ways in which ChatGPT is appropriated to address social, communication, and executive functioning challenges. In our exploration of how adults with ADHD appropriate ChatGPT, we can begin to characterise the design space for developing more effective technological aids for individuals with ADHD.

2 BACKGROUND AND RELATED WORK

In this section, we present some background on adults living with ADHD, key challenges they experience and some key management strategies. We then discuss some of the related work that has explored how existing and emerging technologies have been used to support different experiences of ADHD. We end this section by exploring how generative AI has been harnessed as a tool to support the neurodivergent population.

2.1 Experiences of ADHD in Adulthood: Challenges and Management

ADHD is a neurodevelopmental condition associated with differences in brain structure and function, including in dopamine signalling systems. An estimated 2.6% of adults worldwide (around 140 million) met clinical criteria for ADHD with symptoms beginning in childhood. A broader estimate that includes adults currently showing ADHD symptoms, regardless of when they began, suggests a prevalence of 6.8% (approximately 366 million adults) [130]. With little information about global numbers of undiagnosed ADHD cases, it is recognised that such figures likely underestimate the number of adults currently living with ADHD [59, 133]. Many face significant barriers to accessing diagnosis and care pathways, including substantial waiting times [28, 120, 149], stigma [6, 67, 105, 142], economic obstacles [83], and mythology surrounding treatment [85, 86]. These challenges continue to grow with recent increases in people seeking diagnosis, medication, and therapeutic support [2].

Adults with ADHD often experience a range of everyday challenges related to executive function (EF), attention, focus, emotional regulation, and social interaction. Executive functions (EF) refer to higher-order cognitive processes essential for planning, decision-making, and executing goal-directed behaviours [16, 137]. In ADHD, difficulties with EF can impact inhibition, cognitive flexibility, working memory, planning, and organisation [14, 17, 125, 134, 144]. These difficulties may manifest in areas such as time management, motivation, self-discipline, and concentration [18]. Where these challenges aren't well managed, they can hinder occupational and academic performance [15, 51] and negatively impact health-related quality of life [4, 107, 134, 140].

Adults with ADHD may also experience a dichotomy between periods of "hyperfocus," a state of heightened and intense concentration [79], and "distractibility," characterised by mind-wandering and difficulty sustaining attention [89]. While there can be considerable benefits of heightened concentration and performance

¹OpenAI. n.d. ChatGPT (Large Language Model). Retrieved from <https://chat.openai.com/>

²https://www.reddit.com/r/ChatGPT/comments/16cyik2/adhd_chat_gpt_has_changed_my_daughters_life/

³https://www.reddit.com/r/adhdwomen/comments/1dt025t/hear_me_out_chatgpt_as_an_adhd_hack/

⁴<https://www.additudemag.com/how-to-use-chatgpt-executive-dedction-adhd/>

⁵<https://mashable.com/article/chatgpt-ai-and-adhd>

⁶<https://www.independent.co.uk/news/adhd-ap-people-john-mitchell-experts-b2596313.html>

on certain tasks, experiences of hyperfocus can lead to neglect of other tasks, potentially contributing to time management difficulties and procrastination [111]. Increased hyperfocus has been found to be associated with difficulties such as perseveration (i.e., repetitive thinking or behaviours), emotion dysregulation, and lower task engagement [11]. In contrast, where distractibility and mind-wandering are experienced, work and academic performance can be affected, leading to errors, incomplete tasks, and reduced productivity [56, 89]. Those who experience mind wandering can be unaware of it, which can complicate management [56].

Interpersonal challenges can also be encountered across various domains of social interactions and relationships [128]. Many adults with ADHD report long-standing feelings of being different from their neurotypical peers, particularly in relating to and communicating with them [62]. They may also experience, or fear experiencing, stigma that further complicates their social and work lives. As a result, some adopt masking behaviours [5, 75, 90], in an attempt to hide their ADHD and blend in. This can be emotionally taxing and exhausting [34, 78, 143]. In addition to this, ADHD-related traits can sometimes cause practical difficulties within interpersonal relationships, such as disorganisation, lateness, or difficulties maintaining contact. These behaviours can be misconstrued by others as a lack of care or attention [62].

Emotional dysregulation is another common experience among adults with ADHD [21, 126, 129], often characterised by mood swings and intense emotional experiences. Many also struggle with emotional lability, where changes in emotional state can occur quickly, disproportionately, and unpredictably without obvious triggers [21]. For many, these difficulties with emotional regulation can further complicate their social, academic, and professional lives [21, 126, 129].

To navigate these challenges, adults adopt a wide variety of management strategies. Clinically, stimulant and non-stimulant medications remain the dominant approach [41], sometimes complemented by therapies such as Cognitive Behavioural Therapy (CBT) [82] and Mindfulness-Based Interventions [35]. While these can support a wide range of ADHD challenges [27, 42, 42, 81, 84, 116, 117, 138, 150], access is shaped by stigma [67, 96, 106], healthcare systems [9, 10], cost [135], and recent global shortages of ADHD medication [44, 48, 97, 147].

Beyond clinical care, adults frequently rely on self-devised strategies drawn from lived experience and peer knowledge. These include practices such as body doubling [52, 53], energy management, regular movement or exercise to improve focus [49, 101], and the creation of structured environments using visual cues and personalised organisational systems [38, 88]. Online ADHD communities provide crucial spaces for exchanging these practices, validating experiences, and building collective knowledge [46, 54, 91]. Additionally, digital tools play an increasingly significant role in self-management strategies, though their effectiveness can vary. While general productivity and mindfulness apps are commonly adopted, they often fall short in addressing ADHD-specific cognitive and emotional needs. Some adults navigate these limitations by combining multiple tools or developing complex workarounds, highlighting the gap between available solutions and actual needs. These strategies, while creative, can be challenging to maintain without structured support.

These diverse management approaches highlight gaps between the current support available and the needs of adults with ADHD. While adults demonstrate creativity in developing personalised strategies that combine social, environmental, and technological elements, the effort required to maintain these solutions underscores that existing interventions often fall short in adequately meeting their needs. Understanding how these naturally developed strategies work together and how they might be better supported through technology represents a crucial area for future investigation.

2.2 ADHD in HCI and Technology Research

ADHD research within the HCI community has typically focused on supporting diagnosis and management. Much of this work centres on children and adolescents, with interventions designed to aid behavioural regulation and daily routines. Gamification has been one strategy for engaging children with ADHD in self-regulation practices [19, 64, 122]. For example, Sonne et al. developed *ChillFish*, a breath-controlled biofeedback game that links breathing exercises with character control to make relaxation training more engaging [131]. Other approaches have aimed to scaffold everyday tasks, such as Wills and Mason's [146] self-monitoring application that improved classroom task performance by regularly prompting secondary school students to reflect on their behaviour. Similarly, Park et al. [113] developed a voice bot that assisted children with ADHD in completing daily routines, such as packing for school or doing homework, by providing prompts and reminders to support executive function. While promising, these interventions often prioritise compliance with external expectations rather than supporting the child's own goals and well-being.

For adults with ADHD, HCI research focuses on supporting productivity, organisation, and workplace challenges. Campbell et al. [36] explored the difficulties faced by knowledge workers with ADHD in managing tasks, prioritisation, and time management. They noted that where existing tools like OneNote and Trello were used by some, they often overlooked executive functioning difficulties like task switching and time estimation. Other work has highlighted the socially embedded nature of information management, with Huh and Ackerman [77] showing that adults with ADHD frequently rely on social networks, both online and offline, to shape their personal information practices. Beyond workplace contexts, research has also explored the importance of social media platforms [54, 58, 61, 62, 103] for adults with ADHD to share experiences and coping strategies, although challenges such as misinformation and difficulties that can accompany self-diagnosis have been highlighted by Milton et al. [103]. Furthermore, socially assistive robots (SARs) [7, 87] are being explored as tools for ADHD support. For instance, O'Connell et al. [108] designed a SAR study companion intended to aid college students with ADHD to complete tasks by providing passive support, acting as a "body double" to help with focus and offer accountability.

What emerges across this body of work, from breathing games to productivity tools to study companions, is that it centres on helping individuals manage or modify their behaviour to fit existing environments, rather than questioning how those environments might better accommodate neurodivergent ways of being. This pattern may reveal a fundamental assumption embedded within

ADHD research in HCI - that the problem lies primarily in the individual's inability to conform to established norms around attention, productivity, and social behaviour. Hamraie and Fritsch's [73] concept of *cripping technologies* in HCI introduces a transformative perspective on designing tools for the neurodivergent population. *Cripping technologies* challenge the notion that technology should 'fix' or 'cure' disabilities (i.e., *technoableism*). Instead, they propose reimagining and redesigning tools through the lens of disability, creating solutions that are inclusive, adaptable, and truly reflective of diverse user needs. This approach goes beyond traditional user-centred design, which the authors claim primarily serves neurotypical, able-bodied users [73]. *Cripping technologies* present an important lens through which ADHD-related technology development can be viewed. Rather than framing ADHD as a condition to be 'fixed,' this approach advocates for tools that align with neurodivergent needs, accommodating rather than correcting behaviour. This is especially relevant for adults with ADHD, whose difficulties with executive function, organisation, and focus are not simply problems to be solved but aspects of their neurodivergence that should be supported through thoughtful, inclusive design.

Adding to this discussion on design for neurodivergence, in an influential critique of HCI methodologies related to ADHD, Spiel et al. [133] present a compelling argument for a paradigm shift in technology research. Their examination highlights a pervasive focus on neuro-normative outcomes within the field, advocating for a significant shift toward integrating neurodiversity into technology design. They point to the under-representation of neurodivergent voices in the development process of ADHD-related technologies. By documenting these gaps, they illuminate the disconnect between existing interventions and the needs of the users. Furthermore, Spiel and colleagues contend that the prevalent deficit-oriented approach in current HCI interventions not only perpetuates stigma against individuals with ADHD but also falls short in providing support. They propose a shift toward participatory design practices, suggesting that a collaborative approach with individuals with ADHD could encourage the creation of more relevant and empowering technological solutions. Documenting how and why end users with ADHD use and appropriate significant emerging technologies like ChatGPT to develop personalised coping strategies is one way of giving voice to the ADHD community.

2.3 Focus on Neurodivergent Populations in Generative AI Research

Generative AI research within neurodivergent communities has so far concentrated primarily on Autism Spectrum Disorder (ASD), with smaller bodies of work emerging around learning disabilities, intellectual disabilities, and ADHD. Within ASD, generative AI has been applied across communication, diagnosis, education, and social interaction. For example, language models have been embedded in Augmentative and Alternative Communication (AAC) systems to simplify complex information [141]. Jang et al. [80] explored the application of large language models as communication assistants for autistic workers, aiming to manage daily workplace interaction challenges. Diagnostic applications of generative AI have shown promise to analyse the linguistic patterns characteristic of autism-associated language differences [76], offering new

tools for clinical support. Education-focused work includes systems such as EmoEden, which adapts learning scenarios in response to children's emotional states [139]. Social interaction support has also been explored through AI-driven games and virtual reality environments that foster storytelling and engagement [148]. Closest to the work presented in this paper, McNally and colleagues [99] have described ChatGPT use cases shared by autistic TikTok creators, focused on managing social and practical tasks in both personal and work contexts.

Beyond ASD, research on generative AI has touched on other areas of neurodivergence, such as learning and intellectual disabilities. In learning disabilities, adaptive systems have been developed to personalise content delivery based on real-time user feedback, tailoring difficulty levels and learning styles [1]. For dyslexia specifically, tools such as LaMPost [69, 70] have been designed to improve text readability and writing support, incorporating predictive text input and error correction. For individuals with intellectual disabilities, Saffar et al. [123] explored multimodal AI interfaces that combine text, speech, and visual aids to scaffold complex information and make it more accessible.

More ADHD-focused work includes Moraiti and Drigas [104], who investigated the use of tools like ChatGPT to support individuals with neurodevelopmental disorders, including ADHD. In therapeutic settings, Berrezueta-Guzman et al. [24] evaluated the integration of ChatGPT into ADHD therapy sessions, demonstrating its capacity to provide personalised, adaptive, and empathetic interactions, particularly in fostering engagement among children with ADHD. Expanding on this research, Berrezueta-Guzman et al. [25] examined the efficacy of robotic assistants powered by advanced language models such as ChatGPT-4 Turbo and Claude-3 Opus in enhancing ADHD therapy. Their findings suggest the potential of generative AI for improving therapeutic interactions through increased engagement and personalisation. Complementing these therapeutic applications, Bannett et al. [13] explored the use of generative AI in ADHD medication management, leveraging the LLaMA model to assess the quality of such management in paediatric primary care, showcasing high accuracy in identifying documentation of side effects. Outside of these efforts, there is a notable scarcity of generative AI research in the ADHD community, particularly amongst adults, which is surprising given its adoption by members of the ADHD community.

Anecdotal evidence from online forums and blogs (such as *AD-Ditude Mag* and *Reddit*) illustrates how users from the ADHD community leverage ChatGPT^{7 8 9 10} to organise their thoughts, manage daily tasks, and even enhance social interactions - areas where individuals with ADHD can experience difficulties [39]. Testimonies of ChatGPT helping users prepare for job interviews or navigate complex social situations highlight the potential practical benefits of improving the quality of life. Furthermore, the rising uptake of ChatGPT can be seen in parallel with tools that integrate with OpenAI's models, tailored to the neurodivergent community,

⁷<https://www.additudemag.com/chatgpt-ai-adhd-executive-function-support/>

⁸https://www.reddit.com/r/adhdwomen/comments/15puzcb/chatgpt_is_an_adhd_hero/

⁹https://www.reddit.com/r/ADHD/comments/12ho7cx/how_chatgpt_is_helping_with_adhd/

¹⁰<https://www.additudemag.com/how-to-use-chatgpt-executive-function-adhd/>

such as Goblin Tools ¹¹ – a suite of assistive applications designed to help neurodivergent individuals with task management and executive function.

However, despite their potential strengths and opportunities, any notion of ChatGPT and other LLMs as tools to support ADHD must also give due consideration to their potential downsides. Recent years have seen a growing awareness of inclusivity concerns associated with these models and an increased assessment of their potential for bias in interactions with those from marginalised communities, including those with disabilities [23, 43, 57, 65, 66]. As Choi et al. [43] and Glazko et al. [66] have argued, while these tools can assist with accessibility needs, they may reflect neuronormative biases from their training data. Although there have not been specific studies documenting these biases with respect to the ADHD community, this related work has highlighted the potential for generated language and content to encode biases and align with neurotypical styles, tones, and perspectives. As such, caution needs to be applied to their application as support tools, guided by a deeper understanding of their everyday adoption practices and challenges. This is particularly the case as many end users may have limited literacy with these tools, without understanding how to structure queries or prompts effectively [151] or scrutinise responses. However, given that people with ADHD already use these systems, it is important to consider their perspectives on these issues.

We explore how early adopters within the adult ADHD community are using ChatGPT to serve their self-defined needs as a support tool, aiming to identify additional requirements from such technology. Aligned with the principles of ‘cripping’ technologies [73], this research aims to explore the everyday challenges faced by adults with ADHD, their appropriation of ChatGPT to support these difficulties, and how such practices could be further improved or scaled. By offering design implications through the lens of disability, this study seeks to provide insights for the development of future generative AI solutions that are inclusive, adaptable, and truly reflective of diverse user needs.

3 METHOD

Our research explores how adults diagnosed with, or self-identifying as having, ADHD use ChatGPT as an assistive tool. The focus of ChatGPT as an exemplar LLM-based tool was a pragmatic one underpinned by its central role in the zeitgeist about LLMs when this research was conducted between March and August 2024 and its continued market dominance: for example, almost all of the grey literature we reviewed on the use of LLMs by members of the ADHD community focused on ChatGPT. The research combined an initial onboarding questionnaire, a seven-day WhatsApp diary, and semi-structured interviews to gather comprehensive data on ChatGPT practices and experiences for ADHD management. This study received ethical approval from the Faculty of Engineering Research Ethics Committee at the University of Bristol.

3.1 Participants

Participants were recruited using a combination of purposive and snowball sampling, chosen for its effectiveness in marginalised populations [37, 114]. Recruitment sources ranged from the researchers’ professional networks, including our university’s Neurodiversity Staff Network and student Neurodiversity Society, Reinforce Potential CIC ¹² (a Community Interest Company that offers skilled support for creative, dynamic professionals with ADHD), an adult ADHD charity ¹³, and our social media networks. While recruitment primarily targeted UK-based channels, the study attracted participants from multiple countries, with ten participants from the UK, two from Germany, and one from Australia. Potential participants were screened using a ten-item questionnaire distributed via Microsoft Forms to determine study eligibility. Participants were required to be adults (18+) with ADHD (diagnosed, in diagnosis, or self-diagnosed) who currently use ChatGPT, fluent in English, with access to an internet-connected computer/smartphone, and WhatsApp (for diary-logging).

The inclusion of self-diagnosed participants was a deliberate methodological choice, acknowledging the significant barriers adults face in obtaining a formal ADHD diagnosis (e.g., lengthy waiting lists for assessment, financial costs, gender-based diagnostic biases, and historical under-recognition of ADHD presentations in adults). This also acknowledges the significant personal insight of adults into their ADHD experiences through self-reflection and research before seeking a formal diagnosis. Including participants across the diagnostic spectrum offered potential for a broader understanding of ChatGPT adoption in ADHD-related coping, rather than limiting us to insights from those with formal diagnoses and support processes.

The focus on adults with ADHD already using ChatGPT was chosen to enable analysis of ChatGPT use in ADHD-related coping. These participants represent an engaged subset of the ADHD community who have independently discovered and tried to integrate ChatGPT into their self-determined support strategies. Understanding such sustained, self-driven practices can be revealing of underlying challenges being addressed, the material circumstances of its use in coping work, and key challenges and adaptations faced in attempts to apply the technology. Such early adoption experiences can provide valuable insights for future development and adoption within the broader ADHD community.

Following initial screening, a follow-up call was done with each prospective participant to clarify responses and confirm eligibility. Of 31 respondents, thirteen were selected for participation (8 female, 5 male; Mean age = 34 years, range 22-53 years), representing a range of different academic and professional backgrounds. Participant details are given in Table 1.

3.2 Procedure

3.2.1 Onboarding Questionnaire. Before beginning the main study, participants completed an onboarding questionnaire comprising 36 questions, using both open-ended and Likert scale formats. This was used to collect data on demographics (age, gender, occupation, etc.), ADHD diagnostic status, key ADHD challenges, management

¹¹<https://goblin.tools/>

¹²<https://www.reinforcepotential.co.uk>

¹³<https://www.adhdadult.uk/>

Table 1: Participant demographics, ADHD diagnosis, challenges faced by adults with ADHD, and current utilisation patterns of ChatGPT

Participant ID (gender)	Age	Employment	ADHD diagnosis (type)	ChatGPT frequency of use	Reasons for using ChatGPT to address ADHD-related challenges [*]
P01 (female)	22	Student	Predominantly Inattentive Presentation	Several times a week (ChatGPT 3.5)	Creative writing, Education and learning
P02 (female)	41	Professor	Predominantly Inattentive Presentation	Several times a week (ChatGPT 3.5)	Assisting with productivity tasks, Creative writing, Problem-solving, Social interaction
P03 (male)	20	Student	Self-diagnosed	Several times a week (ChatGPT 3.5)	Problem-solving, Education and learning
P04 (female)	22	Student	Predominantly Inattentive Presentation	Multiple times a day (ChatGPT 3.5)	Seeking information, Assisting with productivity tasks, Education and learning
P05 (female)	33	Clinical Trial Coordinator	Predominantly Inattentive Presentation	Several times a week (ChatGPT 3.5)	Assisting with productivity tasks, Creative writing, Problem-solving, Breaking down daily tasks or generating to-do lists
P06 (female)	22	Student	Self-diagnosed	Several times a week (ChatGPT 3.5)	Seeking information, Education and learning, Assisting with productivity tasks
P07 (female)	48	Lecturer	Predominantly Inattentive Presentation	Several times a week (ChatGPT 3.5)	Assisting with productivity tasks, Seeking information, Problem-solving, Education and learning
P08 (male)	27	Self-employed	Combined Presentation	Several times a week (ChatGPT 4.0)	Assisting with productivity tasks, Seeking information, Creative writing, Education and learning, Creating PowerPoints
P09 (male)	45	Lawyer	Combined Presentation	Once a day (ChatGPT 4.0)	Seeking information, Creative writing, Problem-solving, Education and learning, Social interaction, Assisting with productivity tasks
P10 (female)	37	Deputy Company Secretary	Self-diagnosed	Several times a week (ChatGPT 3.5)	Seeking information, Creative writing, Education and learning
P11 (female)	53	Production Manager	Predominantly Inattentive Presentation	Several times a week (ChatGPT 3.5)	Creative writing, Assisting with productivity tasks, Problem-solving, Seeking information
P12 (male)	30	Project Manager	Combined Presentation	Once a day (ChatGPT 3.5)	Seeking information, Assisting with productivity tasks, Creative writing, Education and learning, Problem-solving, Social interaction
P13 (male)	42	Project Manager	Combined Presentation	Multiple times a day (ChatGPT 4.0)	Creative writing, Problem-solving, Assisting with productivity tasks, Planning weekly schedules

^{*}Reasons for using ChatGPT were selected by participants from predefined categories in the onboarding questionnaire, informed by existing literature and ADHD community online discussions.

strategies, ADHD-related ChatGPT use, and various practical details about contact preferences and diary reminders. Following selection, participants received an ADHD-accessible electronic consent form and a Personal Information Sheet (PIS). Participants were reimbursed with a £20 Amazon gift voucher.

3.2.2 WhatsApp Diary Study. Participants were asked to document their ChatGPT usage over a week using a WhatsApp digital diary.

An instructional video was given to the participants at the start of the diary phase that provided detailed guidelines on diary entries. The participants were asked to record each time they used ChatGPT, the purpose of use, and its effectiveness in supporting ADHD-related challenges. Participants could choose to include their ChatGPT conversation histories as part of their diary entries, but to enable them to maintain privacy and control their data, this was not mandated. Participants could include various media formats in

their diary entries as preferred, including texts, photos, videos, and voice notes. This approach was chosen to facilitate more convenient and accessible participation and enrich the data collected. Daily reminders were sent to participants in the WhatsApp chat to ensure ongoing engagement.

3.2.3 Semi-structured Interviews. Following the diary phase, a semi-structured interview (approximately one hour) was conducted with each participant. Interviews opened with a general discussion of how ADHD affects their daily living, its impact on productivity and well-being, and the tools and strategies used to manage challenges. Having established this context, the interview then focused on exploring the details of documented diary episodes of ChatGPT use. Participants were asked to recall their experiences and recount specific details (including context, prompts, and outputs generated). To aid recall, participants were encouraged to keep their ChatGPT interface open during the interview and reference their conversation history, though sharing screens or actual chat logs was not required. The interview further probed details and rationale underpinning use and, in particular, explanations for prompting approaches and output use. Through detailed discussion of each use case, we explored participants' perceptions of ChatGPT, including both benefits and limitations. When participants expressed predominantly positive experiences in either their diary entries or during the interview discussions, we specifically probed for potential challenges or concerns. Following this, in the third part of the interview, participants were invited to interact with ChatGPT during the interview and were asked to discuss specific features of ChatGPT that helped or hindered them and potential adaptations that could enhance their experiences with ChatGPT. The interviews were recorded and transcribed for analysis.

3.2.4 Data analysis. In analysing the transcripts, we adopted a reflexive thematic analysis (RTA) approach [31–33], recognising the researcher's active role in interpretation as crucial to creating meaning. Both the WhatsApp diary entries and interview discussions provided rich documentation on participants' ChatGPT interactions, combining contextual descriptions and examples from the diary phase with detailed retrospective accounts during interviews. We primarily adopted an inductive method (bottom-up approach) with occasional deduction driven by practical considerations of ChatGPT's potential for assisting adults with ADHD [32, 118]. Our analytic approach was informed by constructionist principles, acknowledging that participants' experiences with ChatGPT are shaped by their interactions with the tool, and that interpretation of these experiences is influenced by our perspective as a researcher [31]. Our approach captured the experiential perspectives of the participants. For example, the analysis aimed to identify daily challenges and explore how opportunities for ChatGPT as an assistive tool could mitigate their impact. We also considered future adaptations to ChatGPT based on current functional limitations highlighted by participants to better suit the needs of the ADHD community.

The analysis followed the key stages of the RTA approach [33]. We began by familiarising ourselves with the data, initially listening to each of the audio recordings and then making several passes through the transcripts, through both the diary entries and interview transcripts, making several passes through both datasets while

noting initial interpretative reflections. We then conducted an additional pass through the data to generate codes and label relevant excerpts. Throughout the analysis, the research team engaged in frequent discussions to ensure the accuracy and consistency of codes. In total, we generated 136 initial codes. The team reconvened to synthesise findings and iteratively clustered the codes into nine key themes: ChatGPT to support masking in communication, ChatGPT as an emotional mediator, security and confidence afforded by ChatGPT, ChatGPT as a support in alleviating brain fog, using ChatGPT to overcome decision paralysis, using ChatGPT to overcome task initiation challenges, using ChatGPT for task engagement, using ChatGPT for focus in information search, and critical evaluation of ChatGPT use.

3.3 Positionality Statement

Our team, comprising both neurodivergent and neurotypical members, brought a range of lived, professional, and academic perspectives to the interpretation and analysis. Neurodivergent team members, including those with ADHD, brought personal insight to the analysis, helping to foster empathy and shape our interpretation of participant interactions with ChatGPT. Neurotypical members, while bringing valuable academic rigor and experience, remained reflexive about their limitations in understanding the lived experience of neurodivergence.

The team adopted a neurodiversity perspective that positions ADHD as a cognitive difference rather than a deficit. We recognise that many challenges faced by individuals with ADHD stem from a mismatch between their neurotype and the contexts in which they have to function. Furthermore, with the majority of team members identifying as women and with conscious awareness of an under-representation of women in ADHD research, there was a heightened sensitivity to potential gendered experiences of ADHD and mediated coping practices.

Finally, as researchers within the domains of Human-Computer Interaction (HCI) and digital health, we approach this work with a commitment to both empirical academic inquiry and a genuine desire to contribute to more inclusive, neurodiversity-affirming technologies.

4 FINDINGS

We present our findings in three sections. First, we explore how participants used ChatGPT to support social communication, particularly in contexts where neurodivergent challenges shaped interaction. Next, we examine how ChatGPT was adopted to assist with executive function, including planning, task initiation, and managing cognitive load. Finally, we turn to participants' reflections on ChatGPT's limitations.

4.1 Using ChatGPT to Manage Social Communication

Navigating social relationships and communication can pose significant challenges for some adults with ADHD, particularly in interactions with neurotypicals [128]. Our study reveals that ChatGPT functions as both an interpretative (deciphering external social

communication) and generative (process of constructing communication intended for dissemination) tool for managing social communication challenges. Many participants were motivated to use ChatGPT as an external support to help them mask their true emotions, particularly in situations where they felt pressure to adhere to societal communication norms. Additionally, participants perceived ChatGPT's default tone as inherently neutral, which enabled them to use the tool as an emotional buffer.

4.1.1 ChatGPT to Support Masking in Communication. A key challenge that participants faced was navigating the complexities of social situations with neurotypical norms. P05, for example, expressed frustration with the perceived expectations in friendships and relationships with neurotypicals, noting, “it seems they [neurotypicals] have certain expectations of friendships and relationships. It’s very difficult to meet those expectations with ADHD.” Challenges of “fitting in” extended across both professional and social environments, with many participants adopting forms of “masking” behaviours (controlling response impulses, rehearsing responses, mimicking neurotypical actions) to help align with neurotypical expectations, avoiding social upset and stigma [90]. This suppression of more natural behaviours requires constant self-monitoring and adjustment, which can be emotionally exhausting to maintain [62, 68], a phenomenon also well-documented in autism research where prolonged masking has been linked to burnout, mental health challenges, and decreased quality of life [102, 119].

We can see such concerns played out where participants were using ChatGPT to “interpret” communications from neurotypicals, being aware of potential discrepancies between their natural neurodiverse interpretations and those intended by neurotypical individuals. The aim here was to try to avoid any misunderstandings that could potentially lead to subsequent social or professional awkwardness.

“[...] it [ChatGPT] also helps me understand what other people may mean by what they say if I can copy sentences across as I often misunderstand meaning [...] So what I’ll do is just type [into ChatGPT] what they [colleague] have said, and I’ll put something like “simplify” [into ChatGPT] [...] even if it’s something like, “Give me your thoughts on this document” - and I’m thinking, what does that really mean? Does that mean that I’m having to write back to you? Do you want an email? What do you mean?” (P05)

Apparent in the above quote is how even seemingly simple communications present challenges in interpreting intended meaning, in particular where it is indirect or reliant upon other pragmatic language cues and context beyond the straightforward literal meaning. These challenges involve not only comprehension difficulties but also the potential for overthinking what might be implied. For P05, copying text-based communications into ChatGPT and using simple prompts like ‘simplify’ provided a way to decode ambiguous workplace requests. When faced with a message like ‘give me your thoughts on this document’, ChatGPT helped them clarify both the intended meaning and the expected format of the response. ChatGPT was able to assist in understanding neurotypical intentions and avoid prolonged overthinking about meanings that otherwise might have arisen.

Beyond text-based communications, such as email or messaging, some participants found related utility in social situations where verbal communications were predominant. For example, one participant recounted using ChatGPT to help understand verbal encounters with others when working on their laptop in Starbucks.

“I’ll be in Starbucks working, and let’s say somebody would be like really weird or like would say something to me or do something to me, and my ADHD and like spectrum thing just goes like, ‘Ahhhhh!’ and then I’m like, ‘What did that mean? Why did they say that to me?’ Instead of going to Reddit and being like, ‘what does this mean?’, with ChatGPT you can just be like ‘what does this mean?’, get an answer [...] then I can be like, OK, I’ll put that [original challenge] aside and then get back to what I’m doing.” (P07)

Here we see how a verbal encounter, involving a misunderstanding of neurotypical intention, can initially be seen as a “challenge” that provokes a negative reaction in the participant. Again, demonstrating awareness of the potential for misunderstanding, the participant first consults with ChatGPT to seek some form of interpretation and clarification. The quote highlights how such episodes, without the interpretive support from ChatGPT, can be disruptive to work being done by the participant, which may incur negative performance consequences. Using ChatGPT helped avoid such disruptions and more easily get back on task.

As well as helping decode neurotypical communications, participants also discussed using ChatGPT to help generate more neurotypically appropriate responses. These participants experience ongoing concern that their natural communication patterns and style might not be clear to others (neurotypicals). For example:

“I’m sending this email, and it is [thought processes], ‘Am I going to offend someone?’[...] I work in a large organisation, so I don’t often know the other people, and I’ve got no idea really who they are or how they might respond to the email[...] I don’t want to put anyone off. [...] I sometimes think things are clear, but they aren’t [...] in my head, it’s clear as day what I mean [...] but then I find with a rewrite from ChatGPT, it just provides that clarity [...] making sure that people aren’t getting the wrong idea and are not confused [...] I think it does a really good job [...] It gives me a bit more confidence that maybe I won’t do that [offend others].” (P11)

As illustrated in the extract, there is a fear that misaligned communication styles could be misinterpreted and cause offence, especially in large organisations where recipients may be unfamiliar with their communication style. In this context, ChatGPT was used as a form of translator, helping bridge the gap between neurodivergent communication and perceived neurotypical expectations. Of note is the perception that ChatGPT’s output conforms to neurotypical expectations. In doing so, it provides further value in facilitating a sense of confidence in their professional context.

4.1.2 ChatGPT as an Emotional Mediator. For some participants, emotional regulation, articulation, and impulsivity in communication represented a particular challenge. Emotionally charged conversations could quickly escalate due to emotionally impulsive

responses, often resulting in prolonged deliberation about how to adopt an appropriate tone. In these contexts, participants found ChatGPT helpful in managing emotional responses by providing a neutral tone. As P03 explained: *“the reason I used ChatGPT was so that it could make me less emotional. If I put in what I wanted to say, it [ChatGPT] would give me that information.”* Further insights into the underlying values of ChatGPT in these emotional contexts can be gleaned from an additional participant scenario. The participant was divorced but had to maintain written communication with her ex-husband with reference to their shared children. Such conversations are delicate and often emotionally stressful, given the potential consequences and impact on the family. The dynamic with the ex-partner is a difficult one, as she explains:

“I have an ex-husband [...] I use it to communicate with him a lot, which is a great tool. I reply to his emails using it [...] I have to prevent myself from replying [...] in an emotional way. And I think ChatGPT is really good for that [...] first of all, by default, I think it’s really neutral. It helps to sort of remove that emotional part and keep the conversation from escalating.” (P02)

The quote illustrates a number of key issues. First, there is a reference to the challenges of control, where she has to prevent herself from impulsively replying. ChatGPT helps provide a buffer here to help temper the emotional impulsivity. Second, she describes how ChatGPT’s language has more of a neutral, emotionally detached tone, helping prevent the conversation from escalating. Before adopting ChatGPT, she explained how she would previously have spent *“hours with friends”* crafting emails to the ex-husband to ensure that they were neutral and appropriately worded. ChatGPT transformed this time-consuming process into a *“30-second task”*, while still achieving the desired neutral communication style. For her, it not only improved the communication content and dynamics but also helped avoid the time and emotional exhaustion that characterised previous interactions.

4.1.3 Security and Confidence Afforded by ChatGPT. The impact of ChatGPT’s communication support capabilities was felt beyond the immediate context of interactions. Participants discussed how ChatGPT’s capabilities afforded them a more general sense of confidence and security about their communications and interactions.

“Every morning is [...] Groundhog Day thrown into the deep end and swim or sink, and now it does feel again that there’s a little bit of a life raft there that you could be like, OK, like, you know, this is something that’s going to help me.” (P07)

The quote highlights the everyday sense of drowning amidst the chaos often experienced with ADHD and the feeling of support ChatGPT offers them. P06 gives a similar account, also explaining how it offered a reliable feeling of assurance - *“I feel secure that I have it and that I can rely on it when I’m doing my essays and my job application [...] I can ask it whatever I want, like with no shame [...] It just gave me a sense of stability [...] I knew exactly where I stood.”*

4.2 Using ChatGPT as a Support Tool for Executive Function (EF)

Many participants reported using ChatGPT in support of various challenges related to executive functioning. In this section, we discuss its use to help with “brain fog”, challenges of decision paralysis, initiating and staying on tasks, and facilitating more focused information search.

4.2.1 Alleviating Brain Fog. Adults with ADHD can experience brain fog, a heterogeneous set of experiences associated with excessive cognitive effort, making it difficult to engage with tasks, articulate thoughts, and express ideas clearly [100, 115]. This block can hinder productivity and expression of ideas, leaving individuals feeling frustrated and overwhelmed [100]. As P05 described:

“It’s kind of like I’m always floating about doing different housework, and then I’m in a room, and I’m like, wait, what? What did I want to do in this room? And then I sort of never get anything done. I go into a room meaning to Hoover or do some housework, and then I spot something like, ‘Oh, that wall needs painting,’ and then I’ll be like, ‘Oh, I’m going to get the paint,’ and the Hoover is still out.” And so, it leads to a very chaotic house.” (P05)

These experiences were further amplified by tiredness and caused participants to struggle to *“substring two thoughts together”* and *“even speak sometimes in proper sentences.”* (P05) Several participants reported using ChatGPT to help alleviate brain fog, describing it as a tool that helps *“unlock their brain”* (P07), enabling them to overcome a sense of cognitive entrapment that hinders their ability to think clearly and effectively.

“It [ChatGPT] made me feel like it was unlocking my brain because I felt like when I would have a thought about something else [...] this is something that’s kind of in my head that is like distracting me or annoying me. And then I’m going to, like, get this out [of my brain].” (P01)

This suggests that ChatGPT served as a tool for cognitive offloading, allowing P01 to externalise distracting thoughts by expressing them to ChatGPT. By providing an outlet to *“get this out,”* ChatGPT helped them clear their mind of intrusive thoughts that might otherwise continue to occupy their attention and impede their ability to focus on other tasks. A further participant described how ChatGPT helps alleviate their distracting brain fog by providing a platform to quickly “brain dump” ideas, allowing them to externalise thoughts – in essence, helping reduce internal cognitive distractions/barriers:

“I would have a lot of ideas, but they would be in there [their brain] and then they would like, need to come out [...] What ChatGPT has done is take all of those thoughts and all of those ideas - in 2 seconds I can just scratch that itch, get it out, and then go back to what I need to do.” (P07)

4.2.2 Overcoming Task Initiation Challenges. Another feature of EF support that participants discussed related to challenges with initiating tasks. As P03 described:

"The problem of tending to a task, so be that cooking, cleaning, planning a day, literally anything that might involve you having to go and just do something, apparently some people will just choose, go over, and just do something. I have never ever been able to just do that." (P03)

Participants highlighted ChatGPT's value in providing a crucial starting point for tasks. As P04 mentioned, *"I'd say it's most helpful in an academic setting for getting me started on something, like just a little push in the right direction so that I can actually start."* The immediate provision of information and direction appears to act as an initial nudge, important for adults with ADHD, who often struggle to take the first step in task engagement. As P06 emphasised: *"I think it [ChatGPT] makes me more productive in general, because [...] having a starting point makes me more productive and more organised."*

ChatGPT helped provide structure and organisation to tasks and information that made them seem more manageable and less overwhelming.

"I think that ties into why I use ChatGPT so much for work. It helps me because it kind of does my thinking for me sometimes. I don't have to think about where to start on this task or how to break it down. It can do that for you." (P05)

While we can view the value of this organisation and structure in purely pragmatic terms, it was also apparent that there was a deeper emotional element to these concerns. Challenges of initiating tasks and procrastination were bound up with considerable anxiety and stress. Multiple participants referred to a feeling of lagging as a result of not starting tasks and thereby completing tasks that needed doing. The cumulative effect of this, across multiple activities, amplified feelings of being left behind, with increasing anxiety further inhibiting task initiation. For these participants, ChatGPT provided them with a *"head start"*, overcoming mental barriers to task initiation.

4.2.3 Task Engagement. Participants expressed concerns about staying on task and described how ChatGPT helped them maintain focus in ways that parallel aspects of body doubling. Body doubling is a productivity strategy where the mere presence (either physical or virtual) of another person helps maintain task focus and engagement, even without direct interaction [52, 53]. Some participants drew explicit comparisons between how they traditionally use other people for maintaining focus and how they experienced ChatGPT's presence. As P08 described: *"I've found it best to manage my ADHD when I'm with somebody else or got prompts from people... just a bit of prompting, a bit of helping, sitting down with me."* (P08) They then spoke further and described how ChatGPT provided similar support that *"stopped me from getting stuck on tasks and gave me a way into engaging with them."*

This parallel between human presence and ChatGPT's role was further illustrated by P04, who explicitly described using ChatGPT as a stand-in for human interaction, where it assumed a function of keeping them on track with their task.

"I think it [ChatGPT] almost mimics that bouncing an idea off someone a little bit [...] how it sort of mimics

another person being there [...] like for example if I'm in the library and if I'm by myself for a while, ChatGPT takes that sort of role where it's keeping me on track and I'm asking it and I'm getting my quick answers [...]" (P04)

Notably, even though ChatGPT currently functions as a passive agent, responding only when directly engaged, participants seemingly found that these interactions provided similar accountability and focus-maintaining benefits to traditional body doubling. As LLM-based agents assume more active capabilities in the future, this points to intriguing opportunities to extend such *"body doubling"* functionality to more system-initiated variants, as demonstrated by P03 *"I would personally like it if it could do something like, umm, if it could like give you responses after some time or you could set up to like help with reminders or anything."*

4.2.4 Distraction and Focus in Information Search. For adults with ADHD, information search via traditional search engines can sometimes prove overwhelming due to challenges with distraction and focus. Consequently, participants would turn to ChatGPT as it could deliver concise and relevant information more precisely tailored to their immediate needs. In doing so, ChatGPT not only provided a more direct route to the desired information but also reduced the burden of sifting through extensive search results. P11 explained:

"It's just so much easier than getting pages and pages of lists that you have to then search through, and you go down all these rabbit holes [...] I've found that I can get really overwhelmed with search results from Google, whereas that [ChatGPT] kind of gives you a starting point if you want to explore further... It kind of gives you a good summary, which is about all the information my brain can handle properly [...]" (P11)

As illustrated here, traditional search engines present numerous relevant options but, by not directly answering the query in a focused manner, offer too many possibilities, which in turn leads to distraction and disappearing down browsing *"rabbit holes"* (P07). In contrast, ChatGPT effectively mitigates these distractions by synthesising and distilling information into concise, direct responses, helping users maintain focus by removing some potential for distraction.

"[...] it catches my eyes in a helpful way, which makes me feel like I can engage with the text [...] It had loads of information that was subheaded, so I knew where to go to get the bits that I needed to read quickly [...] I didn't have to, like, sit there and engage with all the information if I didn't need it." (P08)

Furthermore, with ChatGPT, the flexibility to modulate the amount of information they received helped participants to maintain a sense of autonomy over their information intake. *"Sometimes it [ChatGPT's output] is just written too long. I often have to prompt 'it—'make it shorter or make it two sentences.'"* (P02) This points to potential future opportunities to extend this presentation control further over multiple modalities (e.g., *"more visuals"* (P02)) as needed.

4.3 Critical Evaluation of ChatGPT Use

Participants did share concerns about ChatGPT's general trustworthiness, accuracy, and ability to understand nuanced or specialised contexts, issues that resonate with broader critiques of large language models. However, notably, these concerns were not framed as ADHD-specific. Rather, participants positioned these limitations as universal shortcomings of the technology, not barriers uniquely shaped by their neurodivergence. Some participants described the need to verify information or cross-reference outputs, particularly when using ChatGPT for academic or professional tasks. As P16 explained, *"Because it's AI, it's not 100% accurate... there's always an extra step to correct whatever it says."* P12 observed that *"the likelihood of it hallucinating gets higher"*, especially when attempting more complex prompts. Others noted contextual misunderstandings. For example, P11 shared how ChatGPT would sometimes 'inflate' their small workplace into a large corporation when asked to help with writing tasks.

Despite these limitations, participants did not describe any negative impacts specific to their ADHD. When prompted, they often emphasised that ChatGPT had not exacerbated their challenges. As P05 put it, *"No, I don't think so. I don't think it's made anything worse."*

5 DISCUSSION

In this paper, we have presented an exploratory study of the everyday use of ChatGPT by adults living with ADHD. The work helps address identified gaps in current ADHD and technology literature in relation to adult ADHD and technology-mediated coping practices [36, 133]. The findings highlight some of the diverse ways in which adults with ADHD appropriated this technology to help manage self-identified manifestations of their ADHD experience. We saw how ChatGPT found a place in participants' strategies for managing challenges across multiple domains of their lives - from interpreting social interactions and crafting communications to overcoming executive functioning barriers and decision paralysis. Its presence and ubiquitous availability were felt to be a confidence-enabling crutch, supporting participants in navigating situations that might otherwise cause anxiety or overwhelm. Through understanding these self-determined uses, we offer valuable insights into how emerging technology can be approached and leveraged to further support individual coping strategies that address their in situ needs and contexts.

5.1 Design Implications

5.1.1 Embracing Self-Determination in Technology Research and Design. Linking to calls for more neurodivergent communities to direct design, our research emphasised self-determined use, adopting a broad focus across the lived experiences of these adults without a strong demarcation of the social or professional features of their lives. As an exploratory study, this was a deliberate choice to elicit a broad understanding with a view to further informing more detailed studies in more focused areas. But such an approach is also conceptually important in its openness. Rather than imposing theoretical concerns on the study framing, the approach enabled participants to present their own experiences of where this technology was fitting into their lives.

In considering the appropriation of an existing technology by the adult ADHD community, our relationship to our cohort stands in contrast to some aspects of research grounded in technological solutionism (cf. arguments in Spiel et al. [133]). As Spiel et al. [133] note, while technologies may be well-motivated in their attempts to address challenges experienced by the community, they may also inadvertently frame their ADHD experiences as deficits and problems to be solved. The focus on self-determined appropriation, by contrast, acknowledges participants' open responses to a technological landscape. The episodes of use elicited in the study are participants' adopted choices in the specifics of their context.

Through their appropriation of ChatGPT, our participants demonstrated what Hartblay (2020) [74] terms "disability expertise" - the situated competencies that disabled people develop in negotiating agency given their own capacities, a background of cultural norms, and a designed (not for them!) world. For designers, recognising and supporting such "expertise" means moving beyond creating prescriptive solutions to providing flexible tools that can be adapted and critically engaged with. Our participants' experiences suggest that the minimal and non-prescriptive functionality of ChatGPT supported this kind of expert appropriation, with its use reflecting self-identified moments of personal challenges as well as self-defined framing of the kind of support required to address those. In essence, the technology offered "agency and choice" [133], which could be adapted to their personal needs, context, and strategies.

5.1.2 Fostering Community-Based Sharing and Technological Literacy. A key implication from our study is how the use and value of ChatGPT was shaped and bounded by users' technical literacy, in terms of understanding its capabilities and their ability to effectively craft prompts to achieve desired outcomes. Evidence in the study pointed to some crafting and refinement of prompts to structure responses as needed to address a challenge, but also evidenced certain frustrations where their limited prompting didn't achieve the results desired. This raises several points. First, it provides some indication of value in having greater control over the nature of outputs. Second, given that these users are in relatively early stages of adoption, current use patterns seen in the study may reflect less mature prompting skills. As participants refine and develop their literacy with these tools further, we are likely to see that reflected in more sophisticated uses and strategies for dealing with their everyday experiences. With this in mind, there may be more value in raising literacy with ChatGPT in support of self-determination rather than training focused on ADHD "deficits" [72, 93]. The development of such literacy encompasses multiple dimensions, such as understanding how to craft effective prompts [92, 136, 151], identifying when the system might produce unreliable or inappropriate responses, and developing strategies for evaluating and refining outputs.

Over and above direct training, accelerated literacy development may come from community-based sharing [8, 145] of best practices, usage ideas, and exemplar prompts [55, 112]. This would promote awareness of capabilities as well as the practical ways to adapt and achieve them in practice. Recent research provides evidence of such community-based knowledge sharing already emerging organically. Çarık et al. [39] found that neurodivergent Reddit communities actively share "ND-friendly prompts" and develop workarounds to

address the neurotypical biases embedded in AI responses. Users in these communities experiment with prompt modifications and share successful adaptations, creating a collective repository of strategies for making GAI tools more accessible.

Such suggestions align closely with participants' own comments (e.g., *"I think I'd like to see what other people with ADHD are using and kind of what other hacks are around would be really useful."* (P02)). This peer-based learning could build effectively on existing sharing practices of information in established online communities for adults with ADHD. Over and above skill-sharing, these community spaces further foster critical discussions about the technology's limitations and potential risks, enabling users to develop informed strategies for managing unreliable outputs or potentially harmful advice. Future designs should consider how to integrate peer knowledge sharing directly into generative AI interfaces through features like community-curated prompt libraries or collaborative spaces for sharing successful adaptation strategies.

However, this approach to community-based sharing highlights a key tension in accessibility - while peer learning can democratise access to generative AI tools, it may inadvertently create new forms of digital stratification based on community participation and technical literacy. Such spaces must be carefully designed to include diverse perspectives, including those sceptical of generative AI tools, to avoid creating echo chambers that overlook important concerns and criticisms.

5.1.3 Societal and Ethical Implications. The adoption of ChatGPT as a support tool raises fundamental ethical questions about agency, authenticity, and dependency in neurodivergent experiences. While our participants found value in using ChatGPT across various domains, from communication support to executive functioning assistance, it is crucial to acknowledge the inherent risks and limitations of relying on generative AI-based systems for ADHD support. These tools, trained on vast datasets that may contain societal biases, could inadvertently perpetuate stereotypes or exclude diverse neurodivergent experiences [23, 43, 57, 66]. Moreover, the risk of misinformation is significant, as ChatGPT may produce plausible-sounding but incorrect information [12, 110, 152], which can be particularly problematic when users depend on it for decision-making support.

Beyond these technical limitations, examining participant use cases through the lens of crippling technologies [73] reveals a complex tension. While participants showed ingenuity in adapting ChatGPT for their needs, the very act of using generative AI to mediate everyday tasks and interactions could be seen as reinforcing societal pressures to conform to neurotypical standards of productivity and communication, rather than challenging these normative expectations. This parallels findings from autism research where prolonged masking and conformity to neurotypical expectations have been linked to significant negative outcomes, including burnout, mental health challenges, and decreased quality of life [30, 94, 119]. The use of AI tools for managing social interactions and communication, while providing immediate benefits, may inadvertently contribute to similar patterns of sustained masking effort. Glazko et al. [65] argue that generative AI is not simply a neutral assistant, but a co-participant in identity negotiation, one that can entrench pressures to produce legible, normative expressions of self. Their work draws attention to how even empowering uses of AI can remain

complicit in upholding ableist assumptions about productivity and communication.

These concerns extend beyond individual choice to broader societal implications. Our findings revealed how participants used ChatGPT as an emotional mediator and for masking in social interactions, raising critical questions about authenticity in neurodivergent expression. While such strategies provided immediate practical benefits in managing social and professional situations, they risk perpetuating a world where unmediated neurodivergent expression becomes increasingly marginalised. This is particularly pertinent when considering how generative AI tools might influence interpersonal dynamics and expectations of productivity, potentially creating new forms of pressure on neurodivergent individuals to maintain AI-mediated performance standards.

The ethical implications extend beyond those who have chosen to adopt ChatGPT as a support tool. While our study focused on current users, it is crucial to acknowledge that many individuals might actively choose not to have their experiences mediated by generative AI. This resistance could stem from various valid concerns: privacy considerations around sharing personal information with AI systems, a desire to maintain authentic self-expression, or fundamental opposition to using AI for neurodivergent support. Even among our participants who chose to use ChatGPT, there were some concerns about privacy and information sharing. This complexity around trust and adoption is further complicated by societal stigma, where using AI tools for support can be viewed as taking shortcuts rather than engaging authentically with tasks. These tensions highlight the need to consider not just how generative AI tools are used by those who adopt them, but also why some might choose not to use them at all.

The emergence of body-doubling-like interactions with ChatGPT presents another layer of ethical consideration. While participants found value in these interactions for maintaining focus and productivity, we must carefully consider the implications of supplementing human social support with generative AI systems. This connects to broader questions about how AI-mediated support might influence opportunities for peer connection and community-based support systems [46, 54, 91] that have been vital for neurodivergent well-being. The inherent tension between technological support and authentic neurodivergent expression becomes particularly evident in how participants used ChatGPT for communication support. While the tool helped participants navigate social and professional interactions more smoothly, it simultaneously raised questions about whether such support should aim to help users conform to existing neurotypical communication norms or whether we should instead be challenging and reimagining these norms themselves.

5.1.4 Future Design Opportunities and Considerations. Insights into potential future opportunities for richer self-determination practices with ChatGPT can also be gleaned from the study. As a simple example, some participants in our study made references to the potential value of having more visual modalities as outputs, beyond just text-based interaction. Some of these capabilities are, of course, already emerging, and the bemoaning of their absence here is simply reflective of insufficient GPT literacy or use of limited freely available versions. The point here, however, is that extensions to other modalities are already present in the imagination of these

participants and that as the technology rapidly evolves to encompass new modalities such as speech and vision, we will continue to see new ways in which the system is appropriated in the life strategies of adults with ADHD.

Over and above new modalities, the findings also allude to intriguing opportunities beyond the current passive approaches of ChatGPT engagement, where interaction is initiated by the user. While current use patterns are predominantly pull-based (user-initiated), our findings suggest potential value in more proactive support mechanisms. Future tools might integrate ChatGPT's capabilities with push-based features like context-aware prompts and reminders. In support of EF challenges, our participants referred to things such as setting reminders, pointing to the participants' imagination of more active and integrated functionality. Again, while such agentic capabilities already exist in principle, through workflow automation tools such as Zapier¹⁴, their use remains beyond the everyday levels of literacy required. However, as these kinds of capabilities become more accessible within the bounds of everyday ChatGPT literacy, we will see further sophistication in the ways they become appropriated in self-determined ADHD coping strategies.

Furthermore, it is essential to recognise that while our participants found valuable ways to appropriate ChatGPT for their needs, this should not be interpreted as an endorsement of generative AI as a universal solution for ADHD-related challenges. Rather, our findings suggest that open-ended tools, when thoughtfully integrated and critically examined, can form part of a broader toolkit for neurodivergent individuals, and therefore show promise for a co-designed tool using generative AI. Our study's focus on existing ChatGPT users, while providing valuable insights into successful appropriation strategies, necessitates careful consideration of the broader implications for trust and adoption in the ADHD community. Future research must engage with both users and non-users to understand the barriers to trust and adoption.

5.2 Limitations and Future Work: *"Nothing for us without us"*

This study offers valuable insights into the current usage patterns and experiences of ChatGPT as a tool to support daily activities for adults with ADHD. However, it is crucial to acknowledge the limitations inherent in the study's methodology and to exercise caution in interpreting and generalising the findings. The focus on existing ChatGPT users captures early adopter experiences but potentially misses important perspectives from adults with ADHD who have chosen not to use these tools. Non-users [124] might avoid the technology due to low perceived value, privacy concerns, technological literacy barriers, or a conscious resistance to tools that could encourage conformity to neurotypical communication styles. Understanding these perspectives will be crucial for future research to paint a more complete picture of how generative AI tools may meaningfully impact the ADHD community.

As an exploratory qualitative study of early adopters of the technology, the small sample size derived from purposeful and snowball techniques has certain demographic skews (e.g., occupation, education levels, geographic location, etc.) and is not able to fully

represent the diversity of ADHD experiences globally. While this may serve the purpose of exploring some initial patterns of ChatGPT adoption, the study is limited in being able to explicate how many aspects of identity and background may intersect to shape these experiences. Care, then, must be taken not to over-generalise these findings, and future work can add value through a deeper consideration of how intersectional factors (e.g., gender, ethnicity, occupation, socioeconomic background, age) shape both the experience of ADHD and patterns of ChatGPT-mediated coping.

The WhatsApp diary methodology, while facilitating convenient data collection, may have inadvertently influenced participants' reporting of their experiences. The platform's informal nature and the frequent prompts for entries could have altered participants' behaviour (i.e., the Hawthorne effect) [98]. We also resisted collecting and analysing the specific prompts participants used with ChatGPT to protect privacy. These could have provided deeper insights into how participants adapted the tool for different purposes. Additionally, the reliance on self-reported data in both the onboarding process and the diary entries introduces the risk of social desirability bias, where participants may have presented their experiences in a more favourable light [71]. It is imperative to interpret the study's findings within the specific context of the participants' experiences and to refrain from overgeneralising the effectiveness of ChatGPT as a support technology for all adults with ADHD.

Critical to advancing opportunities in generative AI and adult ADHD is the need for rigorous evaluation of both current and proposed tools. While our study documents promising self-reported benefits, establishing the efficacy of generative AI-based support tools for ADHD requires more systematic assessment. Future research should examine both immediate outcomes (e.g., task completion, emotional regulation) and longer-term impacts on self-management strategies and quality of life. This evaluation should consider not only the technical performance of these tools but also their integration into existing support systems and therapeutic approaches.

While ChatGPT was not specifically designed for assisting with healthcare or neurodevelopmental challenges, its far-reaching capabilities allow users to employ it for a wide array of purposes beyond its original design, including supporting ADHD-related challenges. It is crucial for developers to recognise that their tools may be used in ways that extend beyond their initial intentions, and they must bear a duty of care to users in these broader applications. This duty of care is especially critical for users with ADHD who may experience psychological comorbidities or distress.

Realising the emancipatory potential of generative AI-based tools for the ADHD and other neurodivergent populations will require a fundamental shift in how we approach the design and governance of these technologies. As Spiel et al. [133] argue in their seminal paper, there's a pressing need to move beyond simply designing for neurodivergent individuals and instead, design with them. By placing the end users as active participants in the design and development process, these tools have the potential to go beyond managing challenges to actively supporting neurodivergent individuals in leveraging their unique neurotypes and strengths. Echoing the principles of the "Nothing for us without us" movement in disability advocacy, future research must prioritise the voices and experiences of neurodivergent adults, not just as

¹⁴<https://zapier.com/>

end-users, but as co-creators and leaders in shaping the future of AI-integrated technologies, particularly when such technologies are envisaged as support tools for these populations. This calls for participatory design methods, interdisciplinary collaborations, and inclusive innovation frameworks that centre neurodiversity in all stages of the research and development process.

6 CONCLUSION

This research shows the viability and benefit of ChatGPT to assist adults with ADHD-related challenges from the experiential perspective directly informed by those with lived experience of ADHD. Participants identified a number of practical benefits of using ChatGPT, including alleviating brain fog, navigating social challenges, supporting task initiation, offloading the burden of masking, accountability for task engagement (body doubling effect) and supporting task initiation. Throughout these practical benefits, it was evident that participants valued the confidence and acceptance that ChatGPT provided. Participants used ChatGPT in ways that existing interventions for ADHD in HCI do not currently provide. This highlights new opportunities and design considerations for developing more effective technological aids for the ADHD community. Only by embracing neurodiversity as a source of insight and innovation can we create AI systems that truly empower and celebrate the full spectrum of human cognition.

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